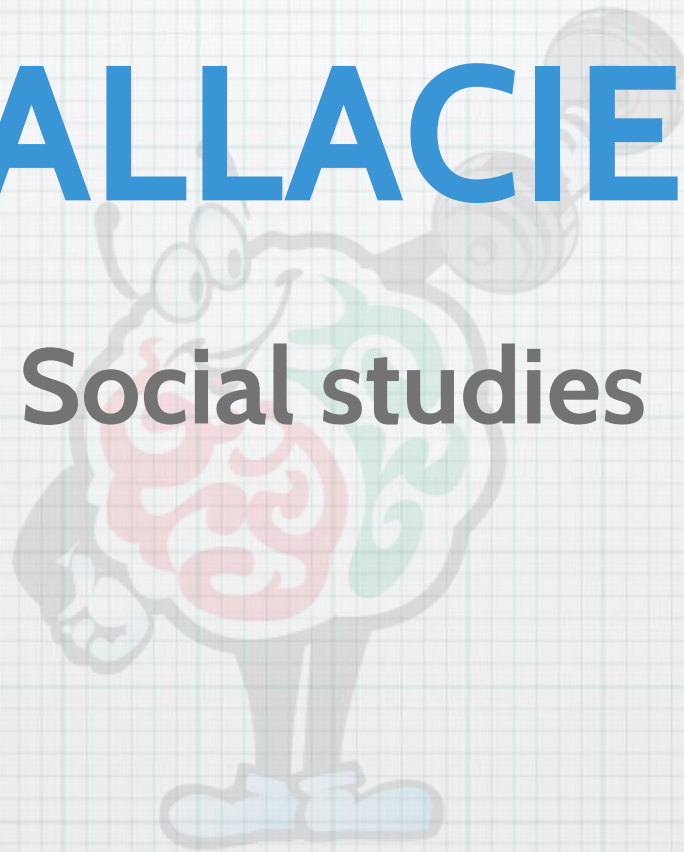


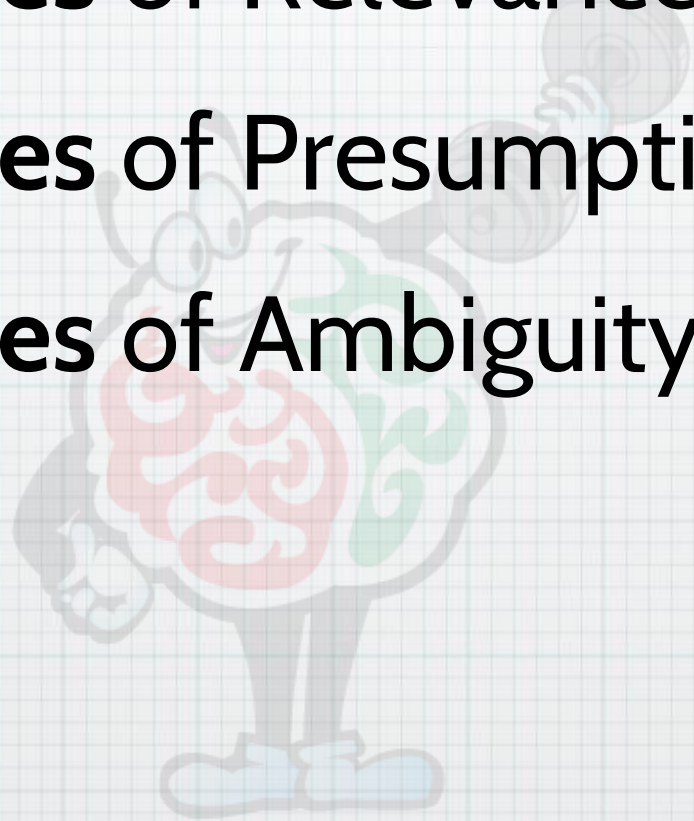
FALLACIES

Social studies



FALLACIES

- 1. Fallacies of Relevance**
- 2. Fallacies of Presumption**
- 3. Fallacies of Ambiguity**



FALLACIES OF RELEVANCE

1. *ad baculum* – Appeal to Force
2. *ad misericordiam* – Appeal to Pity
3. *ad populum* – Appeal to Emotion
4. *ad verecundiam* – Appeal to Authority
5. *ad hominem* – Mirror-image: appeal to authority
6. *ad ignoratium* – Appeal to Ignorance
7. *ignoratio elenchi* – Irrelevant Conclusion

AD BACULUM – APPEAL TO FORCE

In the ***appeal to force***, someone in a position of power threatens to bring down unfortunate consequences upon anyone who dares to disagree with a proffered proposition. Although it is rarely developed so explicitly, a fallacy of this type might propose:

If you do not agree with my political opinions, you will receive a grade of F for this course.

I believe that Herbert Hoover was the greatest President of the United States.

Therefore, Herbert Hoover was the greatest President of the United States.

AD MISERICORDIAM – APPEAL TO PITY

Turning this on its head, an ***appeal to pity*** tries to win acceptance by pointing out the unfortunate consequences that will otherwise fall upon the speaker and others, for whom we would then feel sorry.

I am a single parent, solely responsible for the financial support of my children.

If you give me this traffic ticket, I will lose my license and be unable to drive to work

If I cannot work, my children and I will become homeless and may starve to death.

Therefore, you should not give me this traffic ticket.

AD POPULUM – APPEAL TO EMOTION

In a more general fashion, the ***appeal to emotion*** relies upon emotively charged language to arouse strong feelings that may lead an audience to accept its conclusion:

As all clear-thinking residents of our fine state have already realized, the Governor's plan for financing public education is nothing but the bloody-fanged wolf of socialism cleverly disguised in the harmless sheep's clothing of concern for children.

Therefore, the Governor's plan is bad public policy.

AD VERECUNDIAM

APPEAL TO AUTHORITY

In an *appeal to authority*, the opinion of someone famous or accomplished in another area of expertise is supposed to guarantee the truth of a conclusion. Thus, for example:

Federal Reserve Chair Alan Greenspan believes that spiders are insects.

Therefore, spiders are insects.

AD HOMINEM

The mirror-image of the **appeal to authority** is the ad hominem argument, where we are encouraged to reject a proposition because it is the stated opinion of someone regarded as disreputable in some way. This can happen in several different ways, but all involve the claim that the proposition must be false because of who believes it to be true:

Harold maintains that the legal age for drinking beer should be 18 instead of 21.

But we all know that Harold . . .

. . . dresses funny and smells bad. or

. . . is 19 years old and would like to drink legally or

. . . believes that the legal age for voting should be 21, not 18 or

. . . doesn't understand the law any better than the rest of us.

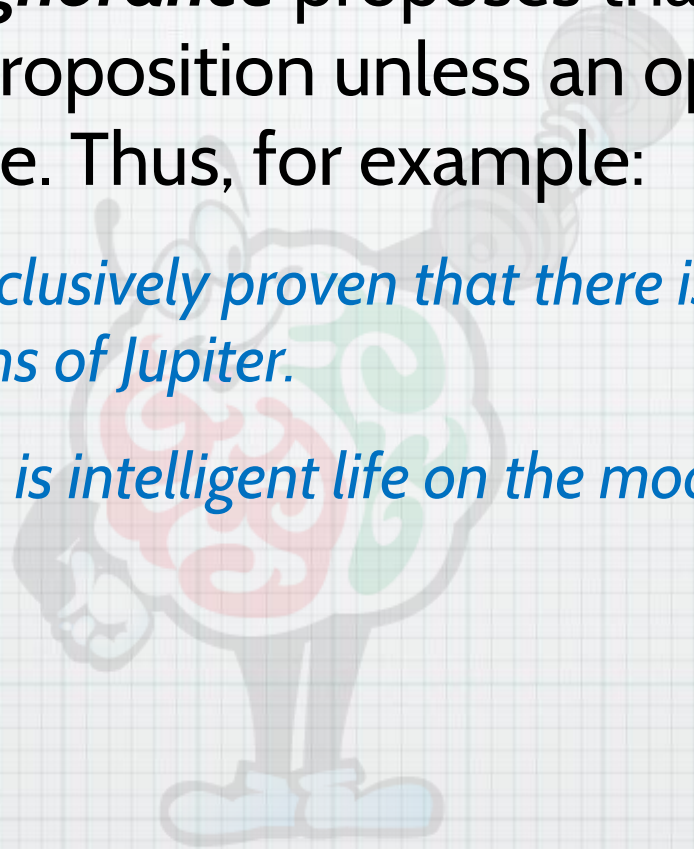
Therefore, the legal age for drinking beer should be 21 instead of 18

AD IGNORATIAM – APPEAL TO IGNORANCE

An ***appeal to ignorance*** proposes that we accept the truth of a proposition unless an opponent can prove otherwise. Thus, for example:

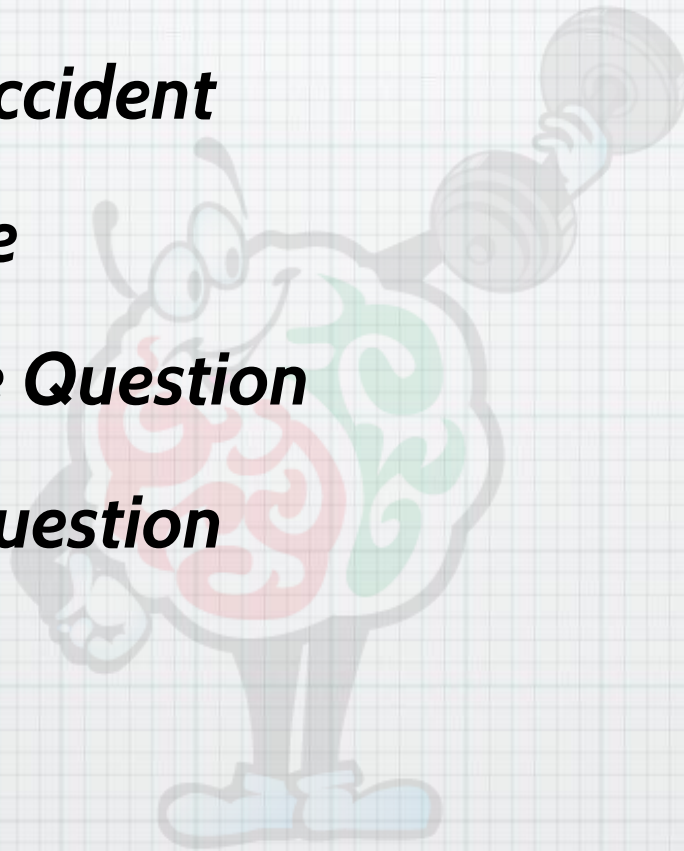
No one has conclusively proven that there is no intelligent life on the moons of Jupiter.

Therefore, there is intelligent life on the moons of Jupiter.



FALLACIES OF PRESUMPTION

1. ***Accident***
2. ***Converse Accident***
3. ***False Cause***
4. ***Begging the Question***
5. ***Complex Question***



ACCIDENT

The fallacy of accident begins with the statement of some principle that is true as a general rule, but then errs by applying this principle to a specific case that is unusual or atypical in some way.

Women earn less than men earn for doing the same work.

Oprah Winfrey is a woman.

Therefore, Oprah Winfrey earns less than male talk-show hosts.

CONVERSE ACCIDENT

The fallacy of converse accident begins with a specific case that is unusual or atypical in some way, and then errs by deriving from this case the truth of a general rule.

Dennis Rodman wears earrings and is an excellent rebounder.

Therefore, people who wear earrings are excellent rebounders.

FALSE CAUSE

The fallacy of false cause infers the presence of a causal connection simply because events appear to occur in correlation or (in the *post hoc, ergo propter hoc* variety) temporal succession.

The moon was full on Thursday evening.

On Friday morning I overslept.

Therefore, the full moon caused me to oversleep.

BEGGING THE QUESTION

Begging the question is the fallacy of using the conclusion of an argument as one of the premises offered in its own support. Although this often happens in an implicit or disguised fashion, an explicit version would look like this:

All dogs are mammals.

All mammals have hair.

Since animals with hair bear live young, dogs bear live young.

But all animals that bear live young are mammals.

Therefore, all dogs are mammals.

COMPLEX QUESTION

The fallacy of complex question presupposes the truth of its own conclusion by including it implicitly in the statement of the issue to be considered:

Have you tried to stop watching too much television?

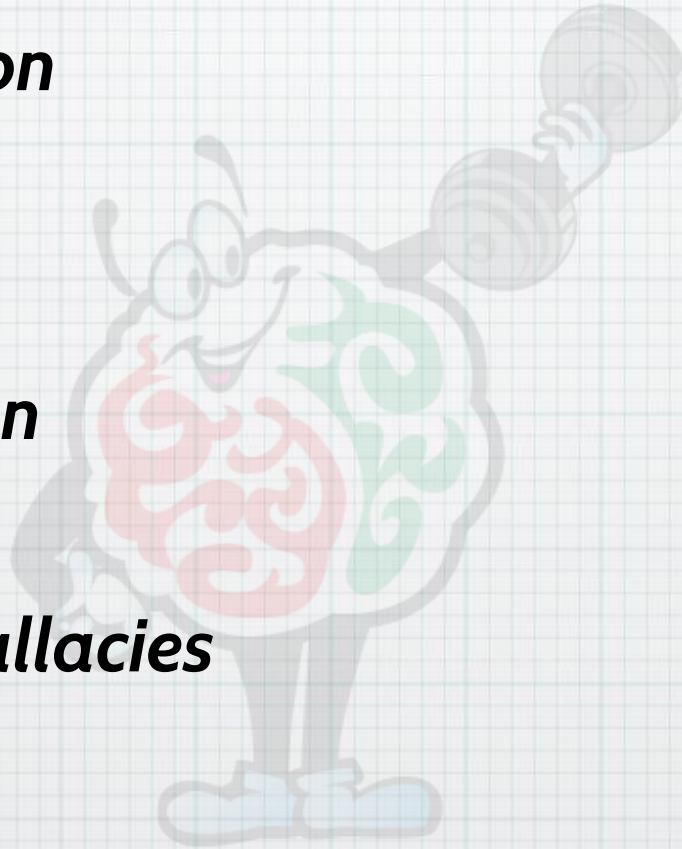
If so, then you admit that you do watch too much television.

If not, then you must still be watching too much television.

Therefore, you watch too much television.

FALLACIES OF AMBIGUITY

1. *Ambiguous Language*
2. *Equivocation*
3. *Amphiboly*
4. *Accent*
5. *Composition*
6. *Division*
7. *Avoiding Fallacies*



AMBIGUOUS LANGUAGE

In addition to the fallacies of relevance and presumption we examined in our previous lessons, there are several patterns of incorrect reasoning that arise from the imprecise use of language. An ambiguous word, phrase, or sentence is one that has two or more distinct meanings.

The inferential relationship between the propositions included in a single argument will be sure to hold only if we are careful to employ exactly the same meaning in each of them. The fallacies of ambiguity all involve a confusion of two or more different senses.

EQUIVOCATION

An ***equivocation*** trades upon the use of an ambiguous word or phrase in one of its meanings in one of the propositions of an argument but also in another of its meanings in a second proposition.

Really exciting novels are rare.

But rare books are expensive.

Therefore, really exciting novels are expensive.

AMPHIBOLY

An amphiboly can occur even when every term in an argument is univocal, if the grammatical construction of a sentence creates its own ambiguity.

A reckless motorist Thursday struck and injured a student who was jogging through the campus in his pickup truck.

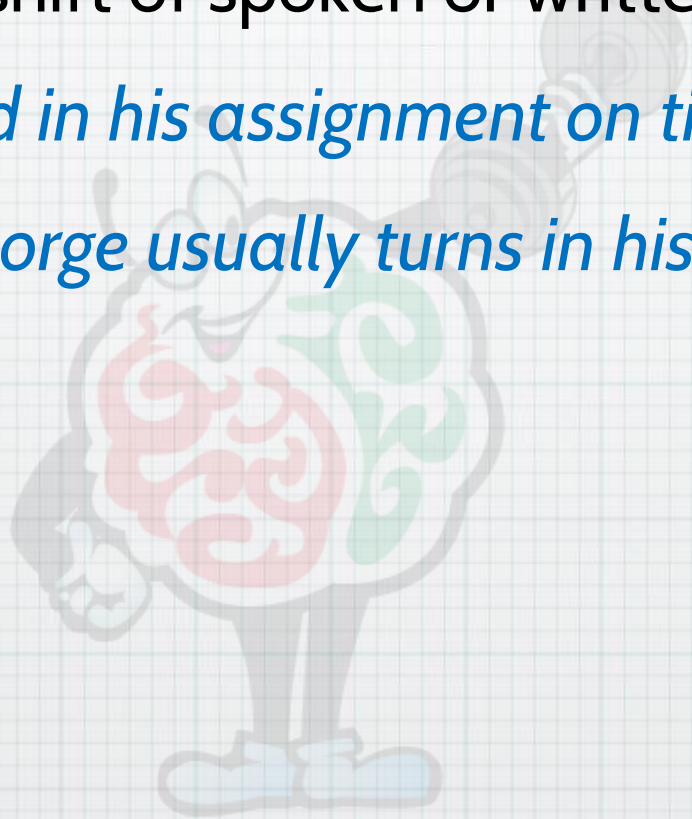
Therefore, it is unsafe to jog in your pickup truck.

ACCENT

The fallacy of accent arises from an ambiguity produced by a shift of spoken or written emphasis.

Jorge turned in his assignment on time today.

Therefore, Jorge usually turns in his assignments late.



COMPOSITION

The fallacy of composition involves an inference from the attribution of some feature to every individual member of a class (or part of a greater whole) to the possession of the same feature by the entire class (or whole).

Every course I took in college was well-organized.

Therefore, my college education was well-organized.

DIVISION

Similarly, the fallacy of division involves an inference from the attribution of some feature to an entire class (or whole) to the possession of the same feature by each of its individual members (or parts).

Ocelots are now dying out.

Sparky is an ocelot.

Therefore, Sparky is now dying out.